

Credit 1.33

33. Humanist Education: think for yourself!

In contrast, modern humanist education believes in teaching students to think for themselves. It is good to know what Aristotle, Solomon and Aquinas thought about politics, art and economics; yet since the supreme source of meaning and authority lies within ourselves, it is far more important to know what *you* think about these matters. Ask a teacher – whether in kindergarten, school or college – what she is trying to teach. 'Well,' she will answer, 'I teach the kids history, or quantum physics, or art – but above all I try to teach them to think for themselves.' It may not always succeed, but that is what humanist education seeks to do.

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As the source of meaning and authority was relocated from the sky to human feelings, the nature of the entire cosmos changed. The exterior universe – hitherto teeming with gods, muses, fairies and ghouls – became empty space. The interior world – hitherto an insignificant enclave of crude passions – became deep and rich beyond measure. Angels and demons were transformed from real entities roaming the forests and deserts of the world into inner